

Post and Say the Language Goal

Students hit targets they can see.

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Why it works

A content objective tells students what they will learn. A language goal tells them what they will have to say or write to prove it. English learners are graded on both every day, but usually only the first one is posted. Naming the second takes one line on the board.

How to do it

- 1 Start with your content objective.**
"Students will identify the causes of the Dust Bowl."
- 2 Ask what students must say or write to show it.**
They will have to explain causes, so they need because and as a result.
- 3 Write it with a function verb and the language.**
"Explain two causes using because and as a result." Then read it aloud.

In your subject

ELA	Explain the theme using "The theme is that ..."
Math	Justify your answer using because and therefore.
Science	Describe the results using increased, decreased, and stayed the same.
Social studies	Compare two causes using both and whereas.
CTE / electives	Sequence the procedure using first, next, and finally.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Points to the posted goal and repeats the key word.	Emerging Uses the target word in a short frame.	Progressing Uses the target structure in a full sentence.	Challenge Uses it twice, in two different sentence patterns.
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Try it this week

Add a language goal to one lesson a day this week. Function verbs to choose from: describe, explain, compare, sequence, justify.

What a visitor would see

A second line under the objective that names a word or sentence pattern, and a teacher who says it out loud.

Preview Three Words

Thirty seconds that save ten minutes.

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Why it works

Students cannot use a word they have never said aloud. Choosing three words and having everyone say them before the lesson removes the biggest barrier to participation. For Spanish speakers, many academic words are already half-known: they are cognates.

How to do it

- 1 Choose three words students must SAY today.**
Not the hardest words in the text. The ones they need for their answers.
- 2 Say it, show it, connect it.**
Say the word, show a picture or gesture, and give the Spanish cognate if there is one.
- 3 Everyone says it twice.**
Once to the room, once in a sentence to a partner.

In your subject

ELA	evidence / evidencia · narrator / narrador · theme / tema
Math	equation / ecuación · variable / variable · solution / solución
Science	cell / célula · energy / energía · hypothesis / hipótesis
Social studies	constitution / constitución · migration / migración · democracy / democracia
Watch for false friends	exit is not éxito (success) · library is not librería (bookstore) · carpet is not carpeta (folder)

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Repeats the word and matches it to a picture.	Emerging Says the word in a short frame: "This is a ____."	Progressing Uses the word in an original sentence.	Challenge Explains how the word differs from a near-synonym.
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Try it this week

Pick three words for one class each day. Put them on the board with the cognate beside each. Keep them up all week.

What a visitor would see

Three words posted, students saying them aloud, and cognates written next to the English.

Hand Over a Sentence Frame

A frame is a ramp, not a crutch.

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Why it works

Most students, not only English learners, know more than they can put into an academic sentence. A frame supplies the structure so their thinking can show. Post one frame for the whole class; it raises the quality of every answer and singles no one out.

How to do it

- 1 Decide what kind of thinking you are asking for.**
Describing, explaining a cause, comparing, justifying, or disagreeing.
- 2 Post the frame that matches.**
One frame on the board before the question is asked.
- 3 Fade it.**
Offer it all week, then cover it and see who still uses the pattern.

What it looks like

Describe	The ___ has ___ and ___. • I notice that ___.
Explain a cause	___ happened because ___. • As a result, ___.
Compare	Both ___ and ___ are ___, but ___ is ___.
Justify	I know this because the text / data / diagram shows ___.
Disagree politely	I see it differently because ___. • Another way to look at it is ___.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Completes the frame with one word or a label.	Emerging Completes the frame with a phrase from a word bank.	Progressing Uses the frame and adds a second sentence.	Challenge Drops the frame and keeps the structure.
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Try it this week

Choose one frame and use it in every class for three days. On the fourth day, take it down and listen for it.

What a visitor would see

A sentence frame on the board and students starting their answers with it.

Talk Before Writing

If they can say it, they can write it.

Why it works

Writing is the hardest language skill, and we often ask for it first. Sixty seconds of talk lets students find the words, hear a model from a partner, and fix mistakes while the stakes are low. The writing that follows is longer and more accurate.

How to do it

- 1 Ask the question, then give silent think time.**
Ten seconds. Nobody talks, nobody writes.
- 2 Partners talk for sixty seconds.**
Home language is welcome here. The goal is the idea.
- 3 Then write, using the frame.**
Partners can repeat each other's best sentence. That is learning, not copying.

In your subject

ELA	"Tell your partner the theme in one sentence before you write your paragraph."
Math	"Explain to your partner how you got your answer before you write the steps."
Science	"Predict what will happen and tell your partner why, then write your hypothesis."
Social studies	"Tell your partner which cause mattered most. Then write your claim."
Any class	"Say your first sentence out loud. Now write exactly what you said."

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Talks in the home language, then writes key words or labels a drawing.	Emerging Rehearses the frame aloud, then writes one sentence.	Progressing Rehearses, then writes three or more sentences.	Challenge Coaches a partner, then writes and revises.
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Try it this week

Before every written response this week, give ten seconds to think and sixty seconds to talk. Compare the writing with last week's.

What a visitor would see

Students turned toward a partner, talking about the question, before pencils move.

Check Without Asking “Do You Understand?”

Everyone says yes. Ask them to show you.

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Why it works

In many cultures, telling a teacher “I don’t understand” is disrespectful, and nodding is polite. “Any questions?” tells you almost nothing. A check that asks every student to do something visible takes the same ten seconds and tells you the truth.

How to do it

- 1 Replace the question with a task.**
“Show me,” “point to,” “hold up,” “tell your partner.”
- 2 Make every student respond at once.**
Whiteboards, fingers, cards, or a partner turn.
- 3 Act on what you see.**
Reteach to the five who missed it while the rest begin.

What it looks like

Show me	Whiteboards up: write the next step, the answer, or one word.
Point to it	“Put your finger on the sentence that proves it.”
Sort it	Two cards, two piles: example or non-example.
Fingers	“One finger for A, two for B.” Then: “Tell your partner why.”
Say it back	“Tell your partner the directions in your own words.”

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Points, sorts, holds up a card, or draws.	Emerging Answers with a word or short phrase on a whiteboard.	Progressing Explains the choice to a partner in a sentence.	Challenge Explains why a wrong answer is tempting.
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Try it this week

Ban “Does everyone understand?” from your room for a week. Replace it with one of the five checks.

What a visitor would see

Every student responding at the same moment, and the teacher scanning the room.

Make the Text Reachable

Keep the text. Change the path to it.

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Why it works

Giving English learners an easier text feels kind, but it means they never practice the reading the text and the next grade require. The better move is to keep the grade-level text and lower the barriers around it: smaller pieces, clearer signposts, and a few words explained.

How to do it

- 1 Chunk it and number it.**
Number the paragraphs. Assign one chunk at a time with one question each.
- 2 Front-load five words and one picture.**
A short glossary in the margin, and a photo, map, or diagram for background.
- 3 Read the question first, aloud.**
Students read with a purpose when they know what they are looking for.

In your subject

ELA	Number the paragraphs. Ask one question per section instead of ten at the end.
Math	Read the word problem aloud. Students underline the question and circle the numbers.
Science	Pair the lab procedure with a labeled diagram of each step.
Social studies	Give a timeline or map before the primary source, and gloss five archaic words.
Any class	Let students annotate in either language. Notes are thinking, not the product.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Reads a labeled visual version and one key sentence.	Emerging Reads the chunk with a glossary and a partner.	Progressing Reads the full text in chunks with the question in hand.	Challenge Reads the full text and writes the margin glossary for others.
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Try it this week

Take one text you already plan to use. Number the paragraphs, add five glossed words, and put one question after each section.

What a visitor would see

Grade-level text on every desk, with numbered paragraphs and annotations in the margins.

Grade the Content, Grow the English

Two different questions. Two different marks.

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Why it works

When a newcomer's correct science answer loses points for grammar, the grade stops telling the truth about science. Separating content from language keeps grades honest and still holds students accountable for growing their English, one target at a time.

How to do it

- 1 Score the content first.**
Did the student show the concept, by any means: words, labels, a diagram, or talk?
- 2 Give language feedback on one target.**
Choose one pattern, such as past-tense -ed, and mark only that.
- 3 Let the lane decide the format, not the standard.**
Same concept, different ways of showing it.

What it looks like

Rubric	Add two lines: "Content understanding" and "Academic language." Weight content more.
Feedback	"Your claim is correct. This week, check every verb for -ed."
Alternatives	Labeled diagram, sorted cards, recorded explanation, or a conference at your desk.
Avoid	Zeros for blank written answers from newcomers. Ask them to show it another way first.
Remember	A student's plan may list grading accommodations. If you are unsure, ask your EL specialist.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Shows the concept with labels, drawings, or matching.	Emerging Shows it with frames and a word bank.	Progressing Writes it fully; language feedback on one target.	Challenge Meets the class rubric; feedback on precision and style.
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Try it this week

On one assignment this week, give two marks: one for the content and one for the language target you taught.

What a visitor would see

Rubrics with separate content and language lines, and feedback that names one language target.

Test-Ready All Year

A support met on test day is not a support.

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Why it works

English learners are entitled to the testing supports written in their language service plans, but an unfamiliar tool costs time instead of saving it. Students do best when the supports, the question language, and the screen are already routine.

How to do it

- 1 Know each student's listed supports.**
They are in the language service plan. Ask your EL specialist for any you do not have.
- 2 Use them in ordinary classwork.**
Same tools, same way, every unit, so nothing is new in the spring.
- 3 Teach the language of the questions.**
Words like best, most likely, primarily, and except decide the answer.

What it looks like

Question words	best · most likely · primarily · according to · except · which statement supports
Two-part items	Part A asks for an answer. Part B asks for the proof. Teach students to check that they match.
Select two	"Select two" means exactly two. Practice it in class quizzes.
Stamina	Build up to long sittings gradually. Teach how to take a short break and return.
Online tools	Use the state's practice tests so the highlighter, notepad, and navigation are familiar.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Learns the tools and the look of the screen.	Emerging Learns the question words with translations.	Progressing Practices two-part and select-two items with a frame.	Challenge Explains to a partner why the wrong choices are wrong.
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Try it this week

Add one two-part question and one "select two" question to a quiz this week, and teach one question word a day.

What a visitor would see

Classroom quizzes that look like the test, and students using their listed supports without being reminded.

Families and Wins

The first call home should be good news.

Why it works

Many of our families want to be involved and are unsure they are welcome, especially when no one at school speaks their language. One short positive contact changes that, and it changes how a student walks into your room the next day.

How to do it

- 1 Make one positive contact.**
A two-sentence note or call about something the student did well.
- 2 Use an adult interpreter or a translated note.**
Never the student, and never a sibling, for anything about grades or behavior.
- 3 Tell families one thing to do.**
"Ask your child to explain today's lesson in Spanish." That is real homework help.

What it looks like

Say it	"Buenas tardes. Soy el maestro / la maestra de _____. Llamo con buenas noticias."
The news	"_____ trabajó muy bien esta semana. Estoy orgulloso / orgullosa de su esfuerzo."
The ask	"Pídale que le explique en español lo que aprendió hoy."
Close	"Gracias por su apoyo. Estoy a sus órdenes."
Need help?	Ask your EL specialist or a district interpreter to translate the message or make the call with you.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Celebrate: first full sentence spoken in class.	Emerging Celebrate: first paragraph written with a frame.	Progressing Celebrate: first answer given without the frame.	Challenge Celebrate: coaching a newer classmate.
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Try it this week

Make one positive contact with an English learner's family before Friday. Then decide which of the nine moves stuck, and which one you want help with.

What a visitor would see

Families who have heard good news from school, and students who know their teachers noticed.